

The Cares of This Life

Since we are uncovering Satan's tactics, go to Mark 4 and begin with verse 13.

And he said unto them,
Know ye not this parable?
and how then will ye know all parables?

Then He gave the subject of the parable:

The sower soweth the word.

The objective of this parable is how you can take the Word of God and guard against these five things: persecutions, afflictions, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things, and turn up to a hundredfold based on the Word of God.

Verse 15 says:

And these are they by the way side,
where the word is sown;
but when they have heard,
Satan cometh immediately,
and taketh away the word that was sown in their hearts.

When He says immediately, He means immediately. That is already a while ago. Before you leave this service, Satan comes, and he is coming after the Word of God.

Contrary to how good I sing, the devil is not after my popular voice. He wants to remove the Word of God out of me because that is what makes me dangerous. He knows the longer he fails to remove it out of my heart, the greater the risk that one day I will come to the place, based on that Word, where I will produce a hundredfold, draw my two-edged sword, split him wide open from the top of his head to the bottom of his feet, and take about three billion people home to be with Jesus.

He must remove it. He must, at all costs. It is the Word of God in you that he is after.

We covered persecutions and afflictions yesterday. Now we are going to the next group:

And these are they which are sown among thorns;
such as hear the word,
And the cares of this world,
and the deceitfulness of riches,
and the lusts of other things entering in,
choke the word,
and it becometh unfruitful.

Notice: the Word of God that was choked out of you becomes unfruitful.

Tonight, let us major on cares, the cares of this life. The cares of this life enter in for one reason alone: to choke the Word of God out of you before it can produce its answer.

We do not have to go very far to find out what "cares" means. This word refers to the everyday pressures that come against us in maintaining an everyday existence.

I like what Webster says about care: care implies anxiety of the mind, troubled by grief, weighed down by responsibility, and disquieted by apprehension.

No wonder He said:

Humble yourselves therefore under the mighty hand of God,
that he may exalt you in due time:
Casting all your care upon him;
for he careth for you.

How many times has someone said, "Brother Roberson, take care"?

Why do you want me to take it? What are you speaking over me?

But you know as well as I do that when someone says "take care," what they usually mean is to be diligent against care. Be diligent to guard against what could come up. Do the necessary things: meditate, pray, spend time with God. Take care that these things do not overtake you.

In that sense, it becomes positive. But in the negative sense, when care enters in, it will choke the Word of God.

Notice verse 20:

And these are they which are sown on good ground;
such as hear the word,
and receive it,
and bring forth fruit,
some thirtyfold,
some sixty,
and some an hundred.

Good ground. I like that.

After verse 20, Jesus does not mention negative ground anymore. As a matter of fact, from this point forward, He speaks on positive ground until He finishes the parable.

Verse 26 says:

So is the kingdom of God,
as if a man should cast seed into the ground;
And should sleep,
and rise night and day,
and the seed should spring and grow up,
he knoweth not how.
For the earth bringeth forth fruit of herself;
first the blade,
then the ear,
after that the full corn in the ear.

There is nothing negative about that.

Then He says in verse 30:

Whereunto shall we liken the kingdom of God?
or with what comparison shall we compare it?
It is like a grain of mustard seed,
which, when it is sown in the earth,
is less than all the seeds that be in the earth:
But when it is sown,
it groweth up,
and becometh greater than all herbs,
and shooteth out great branches;
so that the fowls of the air may lodge under the shadow of it.

Faith begins as small as a mustard seed and produces a mighty tree. There is not a negative thing in that.

Then Mark says:

And with many such parables spake he the word unto them,
as they were able to hear it.
But without a parable spake he not unto them:
and when they were alone,
he expounded all things to his disciples.

The same day, when evening came, He said to them:

Let us pass over unto the other side.

When they had sent away the multitude, they took Him even as He was in the ship, and there were also with Him other little ships.

Jesus had taught all day long. I meditated on this until I could see it with the eye of my spirit. He taught in parables to those without, then gathered the twelve around Him and began to expound in absolute detail for hours the mysteries contained in those parables.

I could see the twelve gathered around. God, I would like to have been in that group.

By the time He was finished expounding those mysteries, He was very tired. That is why it says they took Him even as He was. They took Him for His own good and put Him in the ship. I picked up in the Spirit what that verse meant before I read further and found out He fell asleep in the hinder part of the ship.

Is it not exciting to have the Holy Spirit inside you interpreting verses as you go along?

"He does not do that to me."

He would if you learned how to listen and learned how to pray in the Holy Ghost.

They took Jesus even as He was, put Him in the ship, and He got comfortable in the back of it, laid down on a pillow, and went to sleep.

Then:

There arose a great storm of wind,
and the waves beat into the ship,
so that it was now full.

What had Jesus taught? What does Satan come for? The Word.

Who was in the ship?

This proves how dumb Satan is. "Oh, He is in the ship. I am going to sink Him." In one sense, you really are contending with a stupid foe. That stuff that works on you did not work on Him.

In the beginning was the Word,
and the Word was with God,
and the Word was God.

The Word was in the ship, and guess who was after it?

There were other little ships with Him. Did you know that if Satan sinks your boat, it always affects the little ships that run with you?

The boat was full, which means it was ready to sink. Jesus was in the hinder part of the ship, asleep on a pillow. Jesus was full of care, was He not?

Do not tell me a storm like that would not wake you up. The ship is jumping up and down, filling with water. That would wake a man up. Not Jesus. He was lying there asleep with absolutely no care.

I like that. Because He says, "As He is, so are we."

"I am going to get there."

Not without the Holy Ghost's help, you are not.

Verse 38 says:

And he was in the hinder part of the ship,
asleep on a pillow:
and they awake him,
and say unto him,
Master,
carest thou not that we perish?

In other words, "Master, is Your mind not full of anxieties, troubled by grief, weighed down by the responsibility of this situation, and disquieted by apprehension? We are drowning. Do You not care?"

Thank God He was in the ship. Without reading any more, we might imagine He turned around and said, "Boys, you are lucky I am the great celestial go-between, the omnipotent God. Had I not been in the ship, you boys would have gone down. You are lucky I am the Son of God and I was in your ship."

Maybe we should find out what He actually said:

And he arose,
and rebuked the wind,
and said unto the sea,
Peace, be still.
And the wind ceased,
and there was a great calm.
And he said unto them,
Why are ye so fearful?
how is it that ye have no faith?

Would He have made a statement like that if He had not expected something out of them?

Why did He say, "How is it that you have no faith?" Because hour after hour, in minute detail, He had expounded on the parable of the sower. He had told them Satan comes, and that he brings the cares of this life, persecution, and affliction to choke the Word.

After all of those hours of expounding, He says, "How is it that you have no faith?"

What did He want out of them? He wanted them to remember that when they got into the ship, He said, "Let us go over to the other side." Brother, they were going over to the other side, and there was nothing this side of hell the devil could do about it.

If they had heard what they were supposed to hear, Peter could have jumped up in the bow of the boat and said, "The Son of the living God said we are going over to the other side, and we are going over. Peace, be still."

Brother, that ocean would have become as calm as glass. Otherwise, why would Jesus have said what He said unless He expected them to take care of that situation themselves?

Look at another example in Luke 10:38:

Now it came to pass,
as they went,
that he entered into a certain village:
and a certain woman named Martha received him into her house.
And she had a sister called Mary,
which also sat at Jesus' feet,
and heard his word.
But Martha was cumbered about much serving,
and came to him,
and said,
Lord,
dost thou not care that my sister hath left me to serve alone?
bid her therefore that she help me.

Let us examine this. At first I imagined only the thirteen were there, the twelve disciples and Jesus. Under a course like that, Martha should have been able to handle it quite well.

But Jesus had ordained the seventy, and they were traveling with Him. That makes eighty-three. Now we are running into problems. Martha and whatever hired help she had were serving as fast as they could.

I meditated on this until God put me there, and I could see it. They had a large receiving room. They were not poor. Jesus was sitting there teaching the Word of God, and everybody was sitting at His feet. Mary was curled up right next to His toes like a deer that pants after water.

"Do not stop."

Martha would go by the opening from the kitchen to the serving room, look in, and see Jesus teaching while Mary just sat there, soaking it all up.

"Who does she think she is?"

Martha would march back and forth, carrying another great big pot, while Mary was still sitting there. Finally Martha said, "Servants, would you take over for a minute?" Then she went in right in the middle of Jesus' teaching and interrupted the whole thing.

"I want to talk to Mary for a minute, and I want to talk to You, Jesus. Look at this mess. Look what I have to serve: eighty-three people. Look at Mary. Is she not the mistress of this house also? Is Your mind not full of anxiety and trouble? Are You not disquieted by apprehension and full of despair over this situation? Do You not care?"

The woman had a legitimate gripe. She was serving eighty-three people. You would think Jesus would say, "Mary, why do you not honor your sister and go help her in the kitchen? We are almost done teaching anyway."

But Jesus said:

Martha, Martha,
thou art careful and troubled about many things:
But one thing is needful:
and Mary hath chosen that good part,
which shall not be taken away from her.

Martha, you have anxiety of mind. You are troubled by grief, weighed down by responsibility, and disquieted by apprehension. It has choked the Word.

He was not saying to throw away your responsibility. He was saying that long before that incident, Martha had gone the other way. That is what He brought to her attention.

Go to Luke 21:34:

And take heed to yourselves,
lest at any time your hearts be overcharged
with surfeiting,
and drunkenness,
and cares of this life,
and so that day come upon you unawares.

Who is supposed to put a guard on himself? You are.

Take heed to yourselves lest at any time your hearts be overloaded, overcharged, or negatively influenced so that they fail to produce.

The word "surfeiting" means overeating to the dissipation or breakdown of your body. It is living to the lust of your flesh until you are destroyed by it.

He said surfeiting can overload your spirit to where it fails to produce. If your flesh is out of control, it has an effect on your faith. How could it not?

Then He lists drunkenness. If drunkenness is overdrinking, surfeiting is overeating. Both are bad. Some of us eat because our nerves are bad.

The church will not tolerate drinking, and I agree. I hate it as badly as I hate overeating, because both have a negative effect on your spirit. But the church has taken a more positive stand against drunkenness.

Most people drink because they have a problem. At first it may be for fun, but later it is to cope with the pressures of life. The old sinner stays in health as long as a lot of Christians because he can blow the pressure off Saturday night. He will drink himself into oblivion, sleep all day Sunday, and he has blown the pressure off. If you knew the negative effect pressure has on your body, you would blow it off too.

We list drunkenness as a dire, putrid sin. But when you dig to the root, most people drink because they have another problem. Jesus listed drunkenness, and then He listed the cares of this life right with it.

How would you feel if I got up here tonight and said, "Listen, last night the pressure got too much. I want to confess something. I really tied one on. I feel a lot better today. I got rid of the pressure."

There would be an exodus.

"Where are you all going?"

"We are leaving. If you do not have that much control, how can you teach us?"

Yet the same saint will stand up and say, "Oh my God, my bills are due. I have so much responsibility that I do not think I can go on another day," and everybody stands up after them and brags about it.

"Oh, that is completely acceptable."

A preacher will stand up and say, "The care of this ministry, the bills are due. If I do not pull a lot of money out of you people, we are going under. This is the last desperation telegram. Urgent, we are going under."

He will brag about the cares that have come upon him, and you will let him go. But let me send out a flyer saying, "I want to repent to the whole mailing list. I got drunk last night," and people say, "Take me off."

Do you want to see how the religious mind is programmed?

What do we do about our cares?

God only knows how many times you tried to roll them over on Him and then went home and had a face-off with a cherry pie. But that is okay. You procrastinated. "I will do it tomorrow."

How many got comfort knowing you could start tomorrow?

How many of you rolled your cares over onto Him, then turned around, had a face-off with your bills, the problem with your children, or the problems at home, and took them right back again?

Let us look at this in First Peter 5. We want to cast our care on Him, so we had better find out how to do it.

To understand this, we have to start with verse 1:

The elders which are among you I exhort,
who am also an elder,
and a witness of the sufferings of Christ,
and also a partaker of the glory that shall be revealed:
Feed the flock of God which is among you,
taking the oversight thereof,
not by constraint,
but willingly;
not for filthy lucre,
but of a ready mind;
Neither as being lords over God's heritage,
but being ensamples to the flock.

In other words, the elders are supposed to take oversight over the body of Christ by example. I can set precedent and take oversight because I am an elder and an example in the body of Christ.

Concerning those ultra-submission moves in the land, Peter says not to take oversight as lords, not to lord it over people or play God by instilling fear in them if they do not submit to you. There is not a man in this world who has the right to play God over your life.

He says you must rule as examples. If you cannot rule as an example, then you are not fit to rule, not by instilling fear and saying, "Submit to me because I am the authority and you can do nothing without my permission."

I ran into some of this in New England. I came in, rented a hall, and started with twelve people. I had come from Oregon to New England on a one-way ticket, and twelve people showed up.

The woman there said, "Are you worried?"

I said, "I am not worried. What should I worry about?"

The elders in the town were steeped in the shepherding movement. They were upset because I had not asked them if I could come in, so they told everybody to stay away from the meeting. They blackballed me.

Jesus is the One who said to go into the highways, byways, and hedges and compel them to come in. I do not need anybody's permission.

One thirty-year-old woman was under that shepherding-submission movement. She wanted to check a list of books back into the church library. The elder said, "Do not do it." She snuck over and did it anyway. When she got back, the elder turned a thirty-year-old woman over his knee and whipped her with a paddle.

They had to get permission to marry somebody, or they could not marry.

You may not think it is that bad, but there are some strange things out there. What do you think the devil hides behind? They may be Holy Ghost, godly-living people, but that does not mean what they push is of God. God is much more tolerant than you are.

That same little rebellious woman snuck over to our meeting. She had had six operations in her tendons. She could not walk except on her toes because the tendons were not long enough to put her heels on the ground.

I called her out and said, "Ma'am, would you come over here?"

She sat down in a chair. I grabbed her ankles, and He lengthened both tendons.

After the service, this woman was making laps around the auditorium. My wife finally flagged her down and said, "What are you doing?"

She said, "I have never been able in my life to run, nor stand with my feet flat. Now I can."

She ran all the way back to her church, where the elders were having a meeting about our meeting. She ran straight into the elders' meeting and said, "Look! Look!"

They swallowed their Adam's apples. "Well, it is obvious something has happened."

After they talked to me, they decided to be gracious enough to open the meeting to their people. We went from twelve people to about seven hundred in a week. The miracles flowed like water. In that New England area, every third person would go down under the power, possessed with a devil and screaming.

Everybody said, "What is going on?"

I said, "Do not worry about it. God is working."

Devils were coming out screaming. Teeth were getting filled with silver and gold. God had to crack the shell to get anything over to them.

What does submission breed? Submission. Whom are they going to invite? They certainly are not going to invite somebody like me. So to crack the shell, God had to come from the underside.

Peter said you are not supposed to take the oversight by playing lord and God over people's lives. If you cannot be an example, you are not going to hold them anyway, because people cannot be held by anything but the love of God.

If you stay in my church or meeting because you love me, there is nothing this side of hell the devil can do to get you out.

Verse 4 says:

And when the chief Shepherd shall appear,
ye shall receive a crown of glory that fadeth not away.

Then verse 5:

Likewise, ye younger,
submit yourselves unto the elder.
Yea, all of you be subject one to another,
and be clothed with humility:
for God resisteth the proud,
and giveth grace to the humble.

How come they never preach that I am supposed to be subject to you, but only that you are supposed to be subject to me?

He says to be subject one to another. In other words, I have been over the road. I am an example. I have weathered what hell threw at me and come out victorious. I am an example of a man who can use the Word of God. I am supposed to submit my years of wisdom, teaching ability, and maturity to you as the younger. You as the younger are supposed to submit yourselves and your lives to me in the teaching capacity.

Who is the proud man? Pride breaks down to mean absolutely unteachable. A proud man cannot be taught.

The other side of the coin is humility, which he says we need to be clothed with. A humble man is one thousand percent teachable. The definition of humble is possessing an excellent quality to be taught, and always, under every circumstance, choosing the Word of God as the final say-so in your life.

That is a humble man.

Verse 6 says:

Humble yourselves therefore under the mighty hand of God,
that he may exalt you in due time:
Casting all your care upon him;
for he careth for you.

How do I humble myself under the mighty hand of God? By casting all my care on Him, for He cares for me.

How do I cast the whole of my care over on Him? By being submitted, clothed with humility, having an excellent quality to be taught, and in every trying, careful situation, being taught by the Word and choosing it as the last say-so in my life.

That is why casting care is generally not a single act. Some of you are strong enough to do it that way, but for most it is not a single act. That is why so many have had trouble.

The Greek literally means to roll your cares over onto Him. How can you roll your cares over onto Him when you do not know what He said about them? Roll the whole of your care over onto what He said about your problem, and be humble enough to accept the teaching, even if it is at the hands of an elder.

It is a day-by-day victory that needs renewing.

Peter continues:

Be sober,
be vigilant;
because your adversary the devil,
as a roaring lion,
walketh about,
seeking whom he may devour.

Your adversary, the devil, comes to steal the Word. He brings care to steal the Word.

Peter calls him your adversary, walking about like a roaring lion. He said that for a reason. If you have ever seen an African special and watched a hungry lion bring down its prey, then you have imagery for what he is trying to get over to you.

This is serious. The image it left in my spirit was that my adversary is stalking me like a roaring lion, bellowing and ferocious. When I open the door, he is there, waiting for me to walk out on the porch so he can sink his claws into me and rip me apart with his fangs.

It sounds major, but what are we talking about? He is stalking you as a hungry lion, yes. But do you know what Satan uses to stalk you? Cares.

Satan enters in with the cares of this life, and he uses those cares to magnify his strength as a mighty lion that can consume and devour you and tear your existence apart.

That is why Peter used the lion. He wanted you to understand how serious cares are, and how serious it is for you to humble yourself under God's hand and become the teachable one.

Hungry lions do not start hunting when they are already past hunger. When they wake from their naps and their stomach first begins to feel uncomfortable, they go hunting. The longer they hunt without food, the louder they get. They roar.

The good thing about you and me is that we are not automatically devourable. You have to be devourable. The longer he goes, the louder he roars. If he gets weak, he will go to one of those rat hills and roar real loud, scare the little rats out, and eat them.

When he makes the loudest noise, that is when he is about to turn loose.

Peter says:

Whom resist steadfast in the faith,
knowing that the same afflictions are accomplished in your brethren
that are in the world.

Afflictions, persecution, and cares of this life came on your brethren. They came on your elder who has made himself an example.

Peter says to be sober, be vigilant, and resist the devil. The same thing happening to you happened to your brethren in the world. Take your elders as an example. They came through standing on the Word of God and they are victorious, so you know you will come through it.

But what if you have an elder who says, "That disease, that cancer, came on me to teach me something, little submitted one"? What does that do to your chances? You might as well make your arrangements.

In conclusion:

But the God of all grace,
who hath called us unto his eternal glory by Christ Jesus,
after that ye have suffered a while,
make you perfect,
stablish,
strengthen,
settle you.

More than anything else, God wants your maturity. He wants you to grow up in Him. He wants you to come to the place where you walk in the Word, where you are an example and you are getting other people healed.

If He sees you humbling yourself under His hand, totally teachable, devouring the Word, meditating, praying in the Holy Ghost, and casting your cares on Him, the only reason He lets you suffer for a while is because He knows that the faith inside you is being built to the level where you are going to get yourself delivered.

That is the only reason He waits: for the Word of God to become perfected in you and deliver you in due season.

He said:

Humble yourselves therefore under the mighty hand of God,
that he may exalt you in due time.

What is due season? Every seed that is planted has a due season. The greatest victory God has for you is for you to harvest the crop in its due season. When He has to do a miracle, He steps in prematurely. The greatest He has for you is for the sower to sow the Word and for that Word to come to maturity in you, to work your own deliverance.

So after you suffer for a while, He will establish you and make you perfect. That is the only reason He lets you fight it on your own.

"I am a humble person."

No, you are not, not if you are not teachable and not if you are not acting on the Word.

"But I am humble."

No. Part of being teachable is to act. Why be taught if you are not going to act?

The way we cast our care is to be totally teachable and then employ what we are taught.

Once again, the part that comes from the Spirit is when you pray in tongues and speak divine secrets and mysteries, the understanding of the Word. It edifies your spirit and builds the understanding of that Word until the image inside you becomes bigger than the care.

Some of you have tried to confess care away:

"I do not have it."

But you had it.

"I said I do not have it."

I know, but you had it.

When the image inside you gets bigger than the care trying to envelop you, that is when you will have your victory.

When I knew I was going to lose terminal people, when I knew that with everything I did I could not build the image in them in time, I stopped. Then I started building the image of heaven where they were going. Brother, we kept building the image of heaven until some of them lost their fear of dying and got healed.

When you start getting anxious to go, He says, "Okay, that is it. You are going to stay here and work."